TEACHER COPY · VERSION B · the key is in bold, with why under each answer

READING CHECK: "BISCUIT" AND "THE REEDS OF THE NORTH LAGOON"

Version B

Grade 7 · English / Reading · Making inferences and citing text evidence (fiction and nonfiction)

Read the story and the article. Then answer each question. For multiple choice, fill in the circle next to the best answer. For the others, write on the lines.

Biscuit

Fiction · Written for this quiz.

1 Mrs. Abara handed Kiran her spare key and a page of notes. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," she said. At the bottom she had written: Dev will come Thursday to water the plants. Kiran had asked his parents for a pet for three years. Four days with Biscuit felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score.

2 On Monday morning the apartment was silent. Kiran filled the bowl and crouched by the couch. "Here, kitty, kitty!" He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time. He walked to school with his shoulders up near his ears.

3 That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair. Kiran looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled. At dinner his sister Tam said, "So she ate!" Kiran shook his head. "Dev must have come by and tossed it out. She won't touch anything I give her."

4 On Tuesday he tried harder. He waved a feather toy under the bed and sang to her. Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," he told Tam. "And she hates me." Tam shrugged. "Or you're loud."

5 On Wednesday evening Kiran had a math test to study for and no energy for singing. He sat on the floor against the couch, opened his notebook, and forgot to call her at all.

6 After a while, something warm leaned against his elbow. Biscuit sat beside him, staring at the page as if she were checking his work. Kiran did not reach for her. He kept writing, but slower. She stayed until he finished the last problem.

7 On Thursday, Dev was watering the plants when Mrs. Abara got home. She glanced at Kiran's notebook. "I used to teach math, you know." Kiran started to say, "She didn't eat at first," then looked at Dev and stopped. Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him. "Could I come over sometimes?" he asked. "I'd bring my homework."

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Questions 1-5: "Biscuit"

1. At dinner on Monday, what does Kiran believe about Biscuit?

L1 · infer a character's feelings or beliefs

A. He is sure she has started to trust him.

B. He is hurt that she does not like him as much as Dev.

C. He is sure she has not eaten any of his food.

D. He is afraid she has gotten sick.

Answer: **C. He is sure she has not eaten any of his food.**

Why: Kiran shakes his head at Tam's "So she ate!" and says "She won't touch anything I give her" [3]. He does not think she trusts him: on Tuesday he says "she hates me" [4]; he says Dev tossed the food out, not that Biscuit likes Dev, and Dev does not come until Thursday [1]; he gives his own reason for the empty bowl (someone threw it out [3]), not sickness.

2. On Tuesday, why does Kiran tell Tam that Biscuit hates him? L2 · infer why a character acts

A. She slipped away when he waved a toy and sang to her.

B. She hissed at him when he reached under the bed with a treat.

C. She ran right past him when he crouched down by the couch.

D. She sat on the armchair and turned her back on him the whole time.

Answer: **A. She slipped away when he waved a toy and sang to her.**

Why: He "tried harder" with a feather toy and singing, and her eyes "watched him from the dark, then slid away" [4]; then he says "she hates me" [4]. She watched and slid away, with no hiss, and he waved a toy rather than reaching [4]; on Monday morning "the apartment was silent" [2], so she never ran past him; on Tuesday she was in the dark under the bed [4], not on the armchair, and she watched him rather than turning away [4].

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3. By Thursday, what has Kiran most likely figured out about what brings Biscuit close to him? L3 · infer what a character realizes

A. sitting still on the floor and waiting for her to come

B. humming to her softly from across the room

C. resting on the armchair where she likes to nap

D. working on his homework where she can see him

Answer: **D. working on his homework where she can see him**
Why: Two steps: on Wednesday he studied for his math test and she came and stayed "until he finished the last problem" [5], [6]; on Thursday he asks to come over and says "I'd bring my homework" [7]. He was not waiting for her: he sat down to study and "forgot to call her at all" [5]; he had "no energy for singing" [5], and the singing on Tuesday made her slide away [4]; he sat on the floor against the couch [5], not on the armchair.

4. Why does the author describe the blanket on the armchair in paragraph 3? L2 · infer why the author includes a detail

A. to hint that Biscuit had come out to rest there while Kiran was at school

B. to hint that Biscuit had slipped out to eat while Dev was over that afternoon

C. to hint that Biscuit had hidden under it all day instead of eating her food

D. to hint that Biscuit had napped on it at dawn, before the bowl was filled

Answer: **A. to hint that Biscuit had come out to rest there while Kiran was at school**
Why: The blanket is "warm and covered in orange hair" that evening [3], after Kiran was at school all day [2], so Biscuit had been lying there during the day. Dev comes on Thursday [1], [7], not Monday; the bowl was empty and "Nothing had spilled" [3], so she did eat; a blanket she left at dawn, before Kiran filled the bowl and left for school [2], would not still be warm that evening [3].

5. On Monday morning, what does Kiran do to try to get Biscuit to come out? Quote one sentence that shows it, and give its paragraph number. L2 · cite evidence for a claim

Answer: **He calls her and makes more and more noise with the food: "He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time." [2]**
Why: Full credit: calling her or the bag-and-bowl noise, plus one of these [2] lines with [2]: "Here, kitty, kitty!" or "He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time." "He calls her" with no line from [2] earns at most half credit.

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The Reeds of the North Lagoon

Nonfiction · Written for this quiz. Vessa Island, its people and its animals are invented.

1 Vessa Island has two shallow lagoons, North and South, with a strip of sand between them. Tall tolla reeds grew thick along both shores. A long-legged gray bird called the drell nests only in thick reeds. At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails.

2 In the winter of 1961, a storm flattened the reeds around the North Lagoon. The South Lagoon, behind higher dunes, lost only a few. With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off. Some fishermen were glad. They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it.

3 Everyone expected the reeds to come back in a year or two, as they had after smaller storms. They did not. Each spring, green shoots poked up from the mud, and each summer they were gone. Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in.

4 In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk tested the North Lagoon's water and found it no saltier than the South's. Then she went out after dark with a lamp. The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots. Without drells, almost nothing was eating the kibs.

5 The islanders first tried planting reeds by hand. The snails ate those too. So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms and hid them in the last reed clumps. Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring.

6 The change was slow. For five summers the shoots kept vanishing, and some islanders said the platforms were a waste of wood. By 1980, though, every platform was in use, the snails were thinner on the mud, and reeds stood again along the North Lagoon's shore.

7 The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back. If anything, it rose. Young fish hide among reed stems.

8 Selk later wrote, "The storm knocked the reeds down. The missing birds kept them down."

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Questions 6-10: "The Reeds of the North Lagoon"

6. According to the article, in what year did Selk's students build the nesting platforms?

L1 · find a detail in the text

A. 1961 **B.** 1968 **C.** 1980 **D. 1971**

Answer: **D. 1971**

Why: "So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms" [5]. 1961 is the storm [2]; 1968 is when Selk tested the water [4]; by 1980 every platform was in use [6].

7. Why had no one on Vessa Island seen what was happening to the new shoots before 1968? L2 · infer a cause the text does not spell out

A. It happened underwater, where no one could see the shoots.

B. It happened after dark, when no one was out on the mud.

C. It happened in winter, when the islanders stayed off the shore.

D. It happened deep in the reed clumps, where the mud was hidden from view.

Answer: **B. It happened after dark, when no one was out on the mud.**
Why: Selk saw it only when she "went out after dark with a lamp": the mud "was crowded with kib snails" eating the shoots [4]. The lagoons are shallow [1] and the snails were on the mud [4], not deep underwater; the shoots came up each spring and were gone each summer [3], not in winter, and the article never mentions ice; the snails were out on the open mud [4], and around the North Lagoon the storm had flattened the reeds [2].

8. For several summers after the platforms went up, the new shoots kept vanishing. Based on the article, what most likely explains the delay? L3 · trace a cause-and-effect chain

A. The snails had eaten the roots, which take years to regrow.

B. The new pairs nested in the South Lagoon for a few summers.

C. At first there were too few drells to eat down all the kibs.

D. The storm's salt took several more years to wash out of the mud.

Answer: **C. At first there were too few drells to eat down all the kibs.**
Why: Two steps: only two pairs of drells moved in at first [5]; by 1980 every platform was in use and the snails were thinner on the mud [6], and only then did the reeds stand again [6]. So it took many more drells to thin out the kibs. Green shoots came up every spring [3], so the roots were alive; the two pairs moved into the platforms "the next spring" [5], not into the South Lagoon first; in 1968 Selk found the water "no saltier than the South's" [4].

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9. What does the article tell us about drells and young fish?

L3 · infer what the author wants readers to think

A. Selk watched the birds at night and saw them eat snails, not fish.

B. No one had ever seen a drell eat one, and the catch held when they returned.

C. The catch dipped for a few years after the birds came back, and then it slowly recovered.

D. Fishermen had spotted drells taking a few fish before 1961, but never many.

Answer: **B. No one had ever seen a drell eat one, and the catch held when they returned.**

Why: KEY CORRECTED in round 2, and its wording corrected in round 3 to match [2] ("had ever seen," as of 1961). Two steps: "no one had ever seen one do it" [2], and the catch "did not drop when the drells came back" [7]. Selk went out in 1968, when the drells were gone [2], [5], and she watched kib snails, not drells [4]; the catch "did not drop" [7], so it did not dip; "no one had ever seen" a drell eat a young fish [2], so fishermen had not seen a few.

10. What does "clumps" mean as it is used in paragraph 5? Name another paragraph that helps you know, and tell what it says. L2 · word meaning from context, with evidence

Answer: **Small, thick bunches of reeds still standing: [1] says the tolla reeds "grew thick along both shores," and [2] says the 1961 storm flattened the North Lagoon's reeds, so only small bunches were left.**

Why: Half credit: a meaning like "small thick bunches of reeds growing together." The other half: [1] (the reeds "grew thick along both shores") or [2] (the storm flattened the reeds, so few were left), with what it says. A meaning with no paragraph and detail earns at most half credit.

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (4 points)

Write your answer on the lines.

11. By the end of "Biscuit," how is Kiran different from the boy who started the job on Monday? Use RACE: R - Restate the question. A - Answer it. C - Cite two pieces of evidence with [paragraph numbers]. E - Explain how each piece of evidence proves your answer. L3 · infer how a character changes (RACE)

A strong answer: **On Monday Kiran treats the job as a test and chases Biscuit with noise; by the end he sits quietly, lets her come to him, and wants to keep visiting. He planned "to get a perfect score" [1] and tapped the bowl "louder each time" [2]; on Wednesday he "did not reach for her" [6], and on Thursday he asks, "Could I come over sometimes?" [7].**

Why: Score with the RACE CHECKLIST. Strong evidence: [1], [2] or [4] for Monday and Tuesday; [6] or [7] for the end. The Explain row needs how each quote shows the change.

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Skills and level map

Each question's skill and level (1 = on-ramp, 2 = on level, 3 = harder, often two steps). Version A and B test the same skill at the same level, question for question.

Level 1: 2 (18%)	**Level 2**: 5 (45%)	**Level 3**: 4 (36%)

Skill	Questions	How many
infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	1
infer why a character acts	2	1
infer what a character realizes	3	1
infer why the author includes a detail	4	1
cite evidence for a claim	5	1
find a detail in the text	6	1
infer a cause the text does not spell out	7	1
trace a cause-and-effect chain	8	1
infer what the author wants readers to think	9	1
word meaning from context, with evidence	10	1
infer how a character changes (RACE)	11	1

#	Skill	Level	Type	Key (version B)
1	infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	mc	**C. He is sure she has not eaten any of his food.**
2	infer why a character acts	2	mc	**A. She slipped away when he waved a toy and sang to her.**
3	infer what a character realizes	3	mc	**D. working on his homework where she can see him**
4	infer why the author includes a detail	2	mc	**A. to hint that Biscuit had come out to rest there while Kiran was at school**
5	cite evidence for a claim	2	short	**He calls her and makes more and more noise with the food: "He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time." [2]**

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6	find a detail in the text	1	mc	**D. 1971**
7	infer a cause the text does not spell out	2	mc	**B. It happened after dark, when no one was out on the mud.**
8	trace a cause-and-effect chain	3	mc	**C. At first there were too few drells to eat down all the kibs.**
9	infer what the author wants readers to think	3	mc	**B. No one had ever seen a drell eat one, and the catch held when they returned.**
10	word meaning from context, with evidence	2	short	**Small, thick bunches of reeds still standing: [1] says the tolla reeds "grew thick along both shores," and [2] says the 1961 storm flattened the North Lagoon's reeds, so only small bunches were left.**
11	infer how a character changes (RACE)	3	open	**On Monday Kiran treats the job as a test and chases Biscuit with noise; by the end he sits quietly, lets her come to him, and wants to keep visiting. He planned "to get a perfect score" [1] and tapped the bowl "louder each time" [2]; on Wednesday he "did not reach for her" [6], and on Thursday he asks, "Could I come over sometimes?" [7].**

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